GRATITUDE STORIES · CHRISTMAS GIVING PROJECT

The Living Trail

How every box carries the story of everyone who passed it on: the design, a working MVP and the plan to build it



October 2026

THE IDEA

Every box carries the story of everyone who passed it on

“You're the 14th person in this chain.”



Visibility

Every recipient sees the real trail: who started it, how far it has travelled, and their own place in it.

Convenience

Passing it on is one tap, a short checkout and a delivery to you. Busy? One tap sets a 24-hour reminder.

Meaning

Continuing feels like making someone else feel thought of, not an obligation or another sales funnel.

THE RECIPIENT JOURNEY

Six steps from scan to decision

1. **Scan the card** — The QR, or the code typed in, opens this box's own page
2. **Confirm it's here** — "Yes, I have it" opens the story
3. **See who gave it** — "Passed to you by Dayo L.", with their note
4. **Add your name** — First name, initial and area, shown only if they opt in
5. **See the trail** — "You're the 14th person", then your message
6. **Decide** — Pass it forward, ask for a reminder, or not this time

Three answers, all respected

Yes, I'll pass it forward

Choose a box, add a note and pay. Delivered to you to hand over, or straight to them.

Remind me in 24 hours

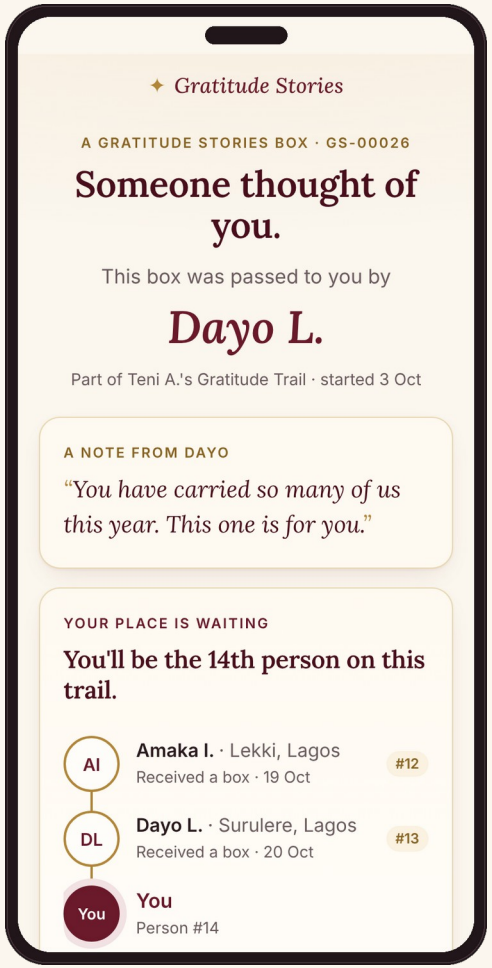
One SMS or email. Its link brings you straight back to this choice.

Not this time

Thanked warmly. Your place on the trail stays part of its story.

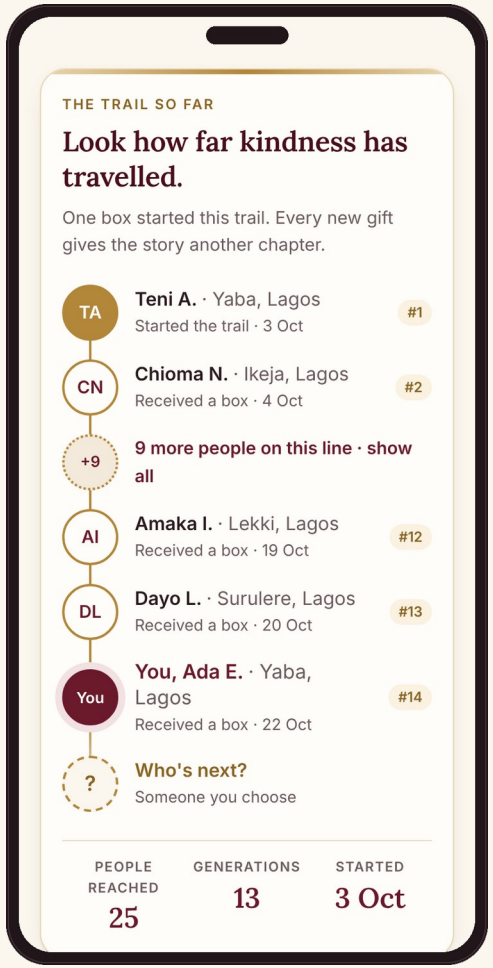
ON THEIR PHONE

What the recipient actually sees



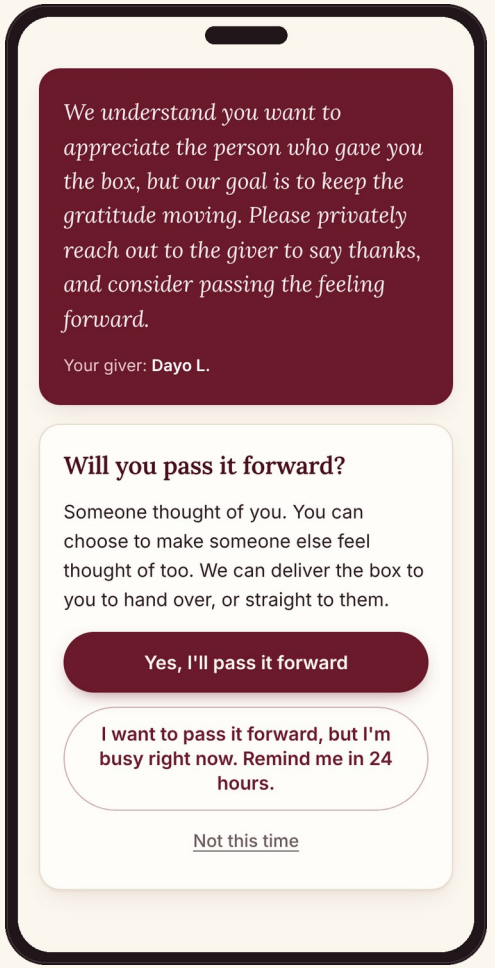
1 The reveal

Who gave it, their note, and the place waiting



2 Their place on the trail

Real people before them, an open space after



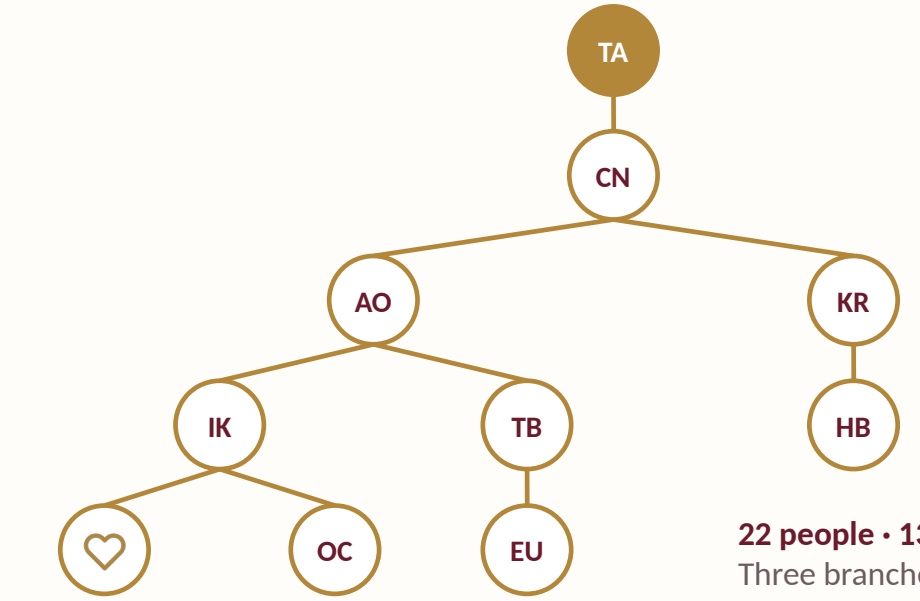
3 The message and the choice

Your words, then three clear options

SEPARATE TRAILS

Teni's trail and Damola's trail never touch

Teni's trail TR-7KQ3MX



+12 more down this branch

22 people · 13 generations
Three branches: someone passed on two boxes

Damola's trail TR-H4D9PW



3 people · 3 generations
One box on its way

Every box stores the trail it belongs to

A new box must match its parent's trail: the database refuses anything else

A box's trail can never be edited; mistakes are cancelled and reissued

IDENTIFIERS

Six identifiers, each with one job

Card code

K7Q4M-X2PZ9

Inside the QR, printed under it

Opens this box's page. Random, so it cannot be guessed

Box number

GS-00042

Printed on the card

Packing and support reference. Opens nothing

Trail code

TR-7KQ3MX

Dashboards and admin

Names one trail

Parent box + depth

GS-00041 · 12

Database only

The lineage: who passed it on, and how far down

Referral token

16 characters

Pass-it-forward link

Carries the parent box from "Yes" to payment

Holder and owner keys

43 characters

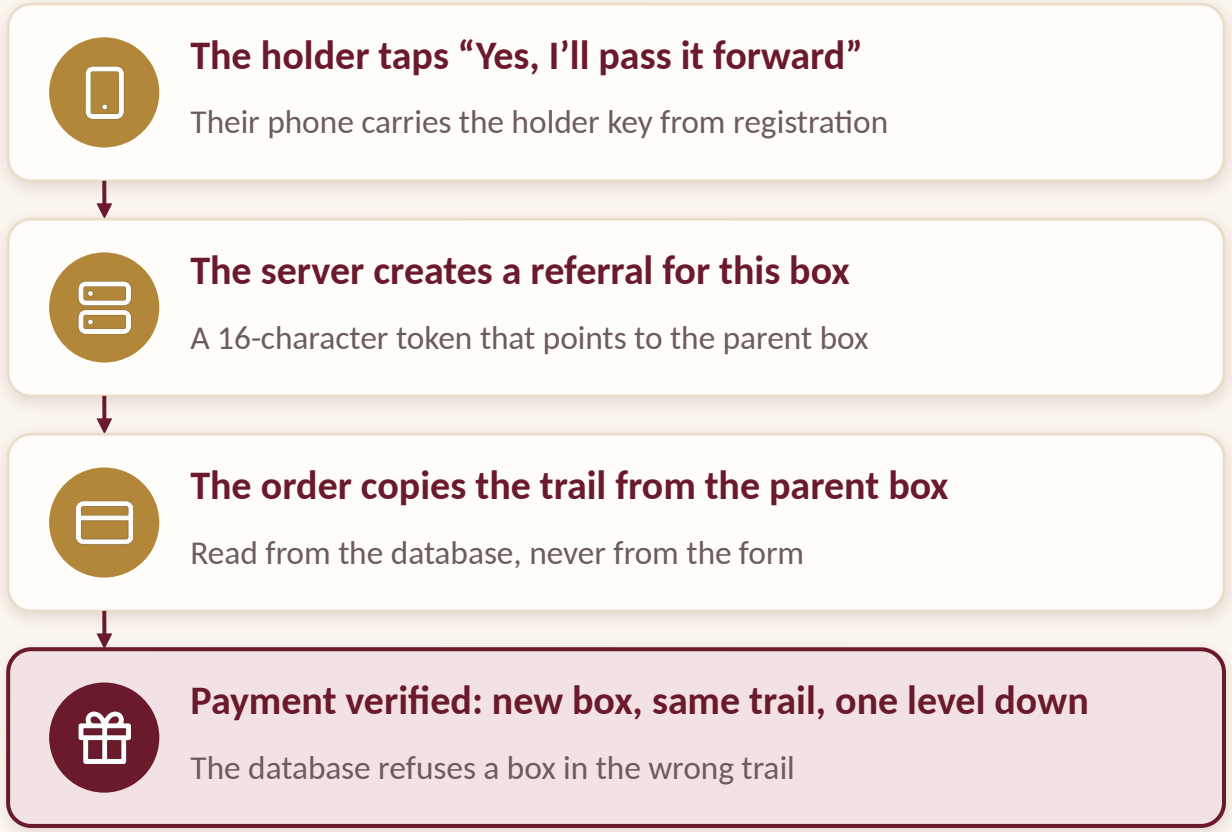
Phone cookie · private link

Prove "this phone registered the box"; open a starter's dashboard

The rule that keeps trails apart

A new box’s trail is copied from its parent box, on the server.

Nothing the buyer types, and nothing their browser sends, can choose which trail a box joins. A test proves it by sending Damola’s trail in a pass-forward checkout; the box still lands in Teni’s.

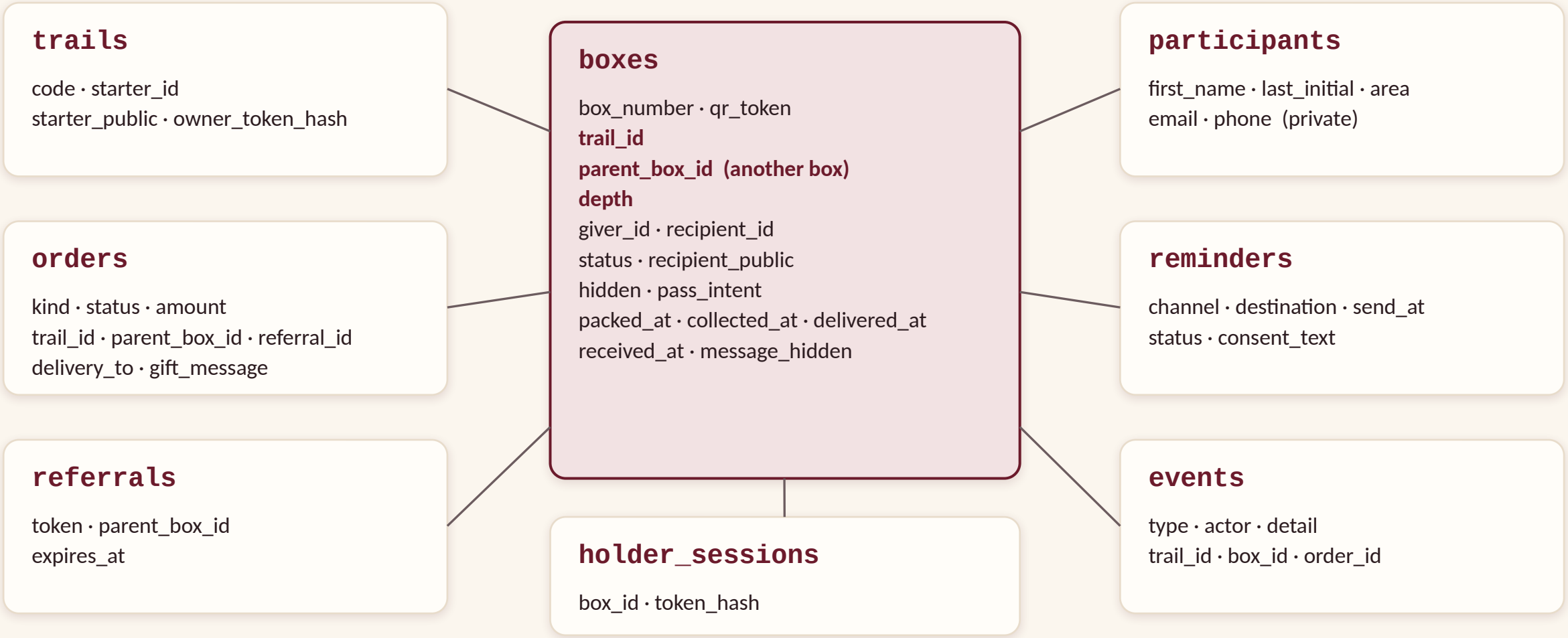


Never decides the trail

- The buyer’s name
- Email or phone
- A field in the form or URL
- A cookie on its own
- A plain site visit

DATABASE

Three columns on one table carry the lineage



Also: products, milestones_reached, charity_unlocks and help_requests. The bold wine columns are the lineage; two database triggers guard them.

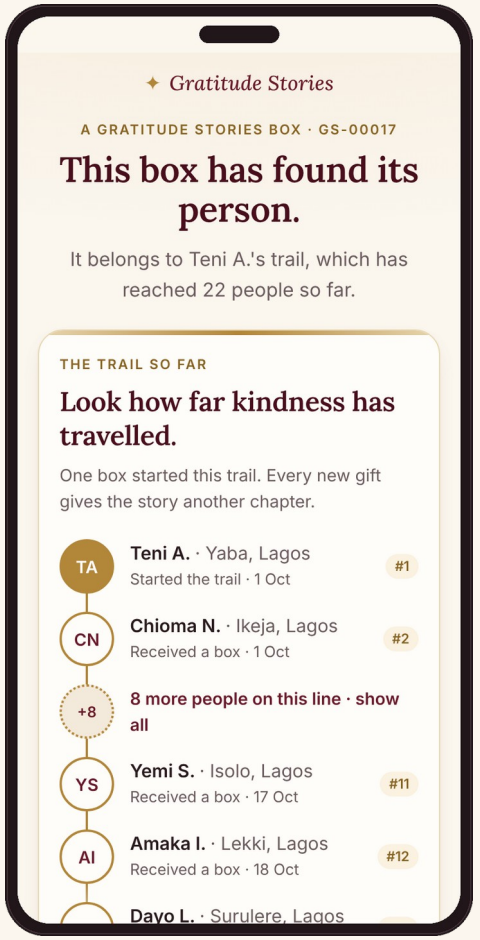
WHEN A QR CODE IS SCANNED

One link, eight states

Checked top to bottom on every scan of /b/<card code>

1 The code does not exist	**Not found**
2 The box was cancelled or refunded	**No longer active**
3 This phone gave the box away (it holds the parent)	**This box is for someone else**
4 Paid, packed or with the courier	**On its way (state 1)**
5 Delivered, not yet confirmed	**“Have you received it?” (2–3)**
6 Confirmed, not yet registered	**Reveal + add your name (4)**
7 Registered, and this is the holder’s phone	**Trail, message and decision**
8 Registered, and anyone else	**Read-only trail**

Wine rows are new in the Box Journey update



State 8: a stranger sees the public-safe trail

WHEN A NEW BOX IS BOUGHT

A box is born only after the payment is verified

1 PHONE

Tap “Yes”

The holder key proves this phone registered the box

2 SERVER

Referral created

Points to this box; valid for 30 days

3 PHONE

Choose and check out

Box, note, delivery to them or to me

4 SERVER

Order saved, pending

Trail copied from the parent box

5 PAYSTACK

Payment

Card, transfer or USSD

6 SERVER

Signed webhook

Signature checked, then Paystack asked to verify

7 SERVER

confirmPayment()

One transaction: new box, same trail, depth + 1

8 TEAM

Packed and sent

Packed, collected, delivered: to the holder or their person

9 NEXT PERSON

Confirms and joins

“Yes, I have it”, then the 15th person



Safe by design

A repeated webhook changes nothing. A failed payment adds nothing.

Paystack retries webhooks, and the buyer’s browser also returns to the order page. Whichever arrives first creates the box; the other finds it already done.

PRIVACY

Safe to show strangers, by design

What a stranger sees

TA **Teni A.** · Yaba, Lagos

A friend · chose not to be shown

BF **Bisi F.** · Victoria Island, Lagos

KO **Kelechi O.** · Ikoyi, Lagos

A friend · chose not to be shown

Never shown on any trail: phone numbers, emails, addresses

Viewer	Sees
Anyone with the box link	First name, initial and area if ticked; otherwise “A friend”
The person who receives your box	Your first name and your note
The trail’s starter	The same public-safe labels, on a tree
The giver of a box	Its delivery status; never whether it was opened or registered
Gratitude Stories team	Delivery details, for delivery and support only

Unticked by default

Names are opt-in

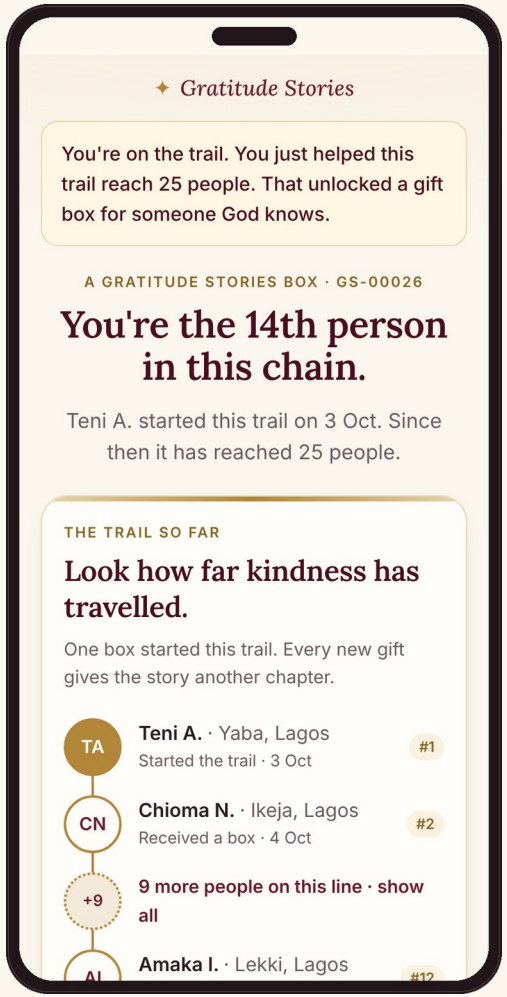
Admin can hide any name

It becomes “A friend”

Ask your lawyer

Under-18s and NDPA registration

Pull, not pressure



The pull comes from real people before you and an open space after you, never from warnings.

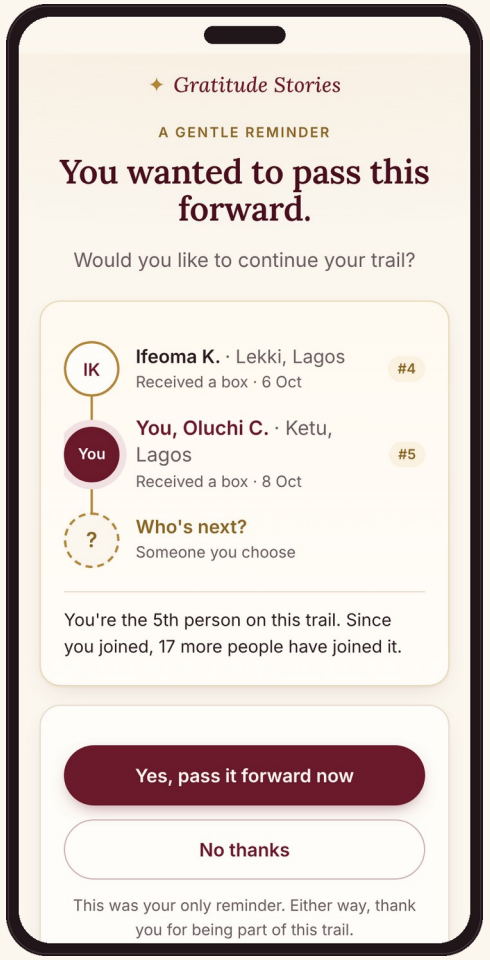
Do	Avoid
“You’re the 14th person in this chain.”	“Don’t let the chain die with you.”
An open “Who’s next?” at the end	A “broken chain” mark on anyone who stopped
“3 more people and this trail reaches 25.”	Counting or showing who chose “Not this time”
Thank people who decline; they stay on the trail	Greying out people who did not continue
Real names, only with consent	Invented activity like “Ada just passed it on!”

Motion is small: the thread draws down, names rise in turn, and “You” glows softly. It switches off for people who set “reduce motion”.

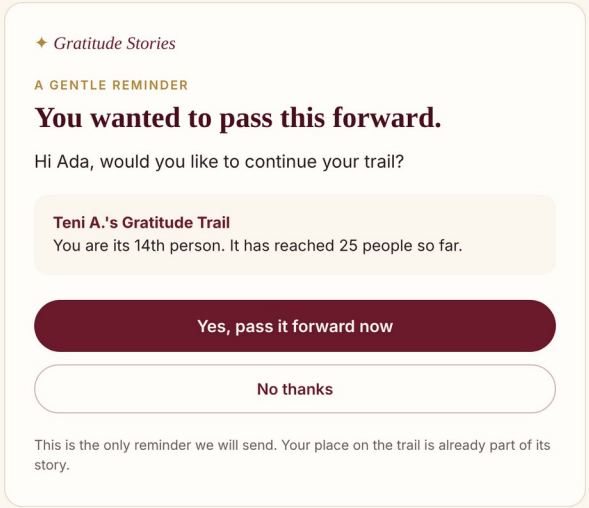
THE “NOT RIGHT NOW” NET

Catch good intentions before they fade

1. **“I want to pass it forward, but I’m busy right now.”**
   One tap from the decision card
2. **SMS or email, plus one consent tick**
   “Send me one reminder about this box. Nothing else.”
3. **One gentle message after 24 hours**
   “You wanted to pass this forward. A gentle reminder…”
4. **The link signs them in on any phone**
   Even if they registered on a different device
5. **Two clear choices**
   “Yes, pass it forward now” or “No thanks”
6. **“No thanks” is final, and thanked**
   No more reminders; their place stays on the trail



Where the link lands



The email: both buttons open the page, so a mail scanner can never decide for them

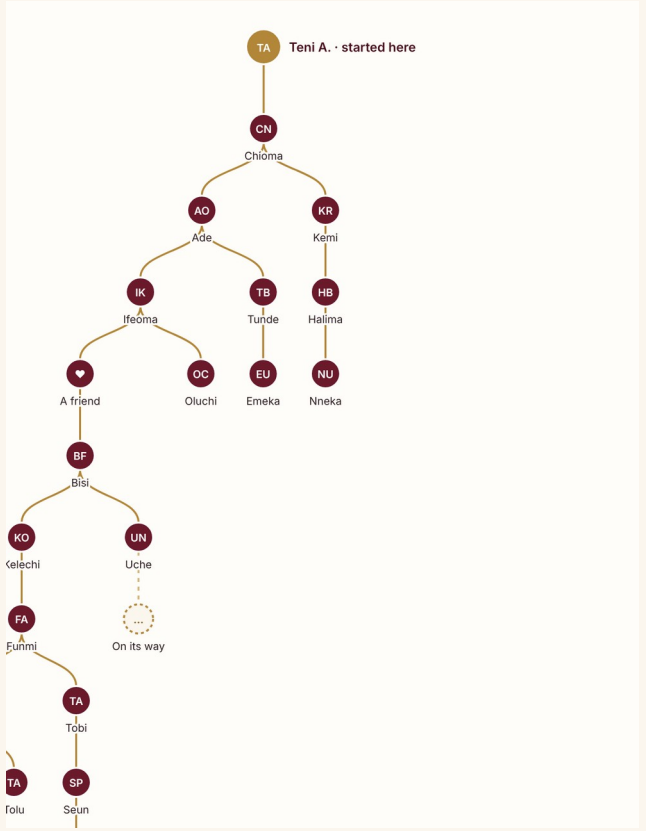
Hi Oluchi. You wanted to pass this forward. A gentle reminder: would you like to continue your trail? gs.ng/r/… This is the only reminder we will send.

The SMS

THE STARTER'S VIEW

Teni watches her kindness travel





The tree: every box, every branch

People reached
Confirmed registrations only

Generations
Confirmed levels of giving

Charity boxes unlocked
Given vs being arranged

UPDATE · OCTOBER 2026

The Box Journey

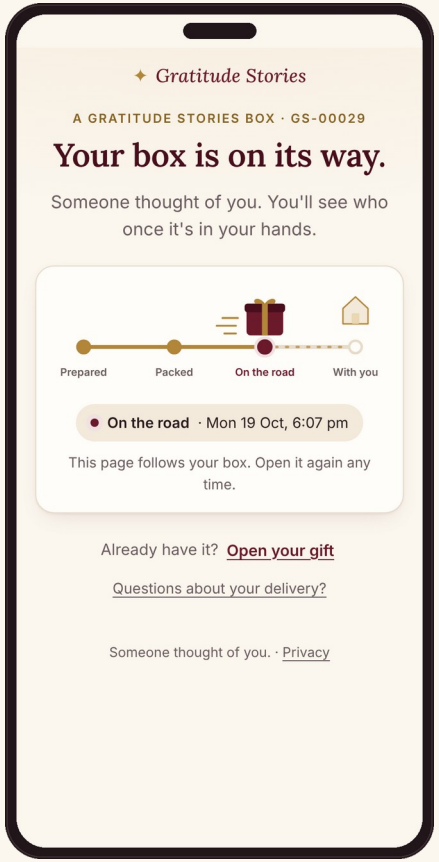
Follow the box, keep the surprise, protect the giver’s privacy, and celebrate how far kindness travels.



BEFORE THEY REGISTER

Four states, and the surprise is kept until the end

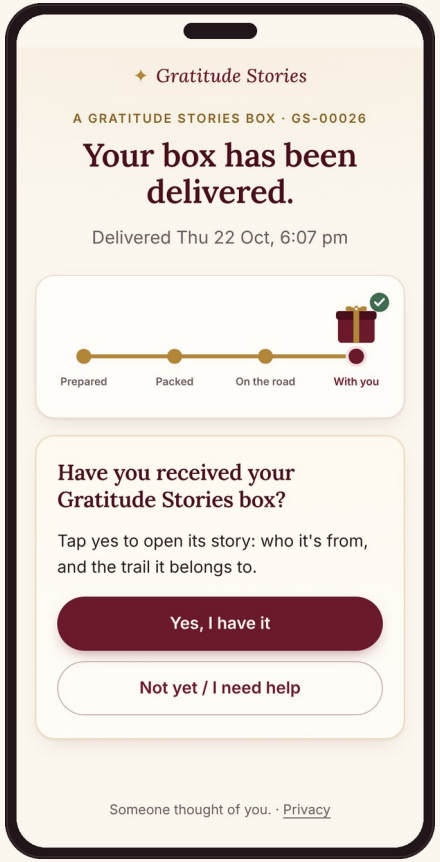
STATE 1 Paid, packed or with the courier



A warm transit view. The giver stays hidden. “Open your gift” appears once the box is with the courier.

Courier delivers

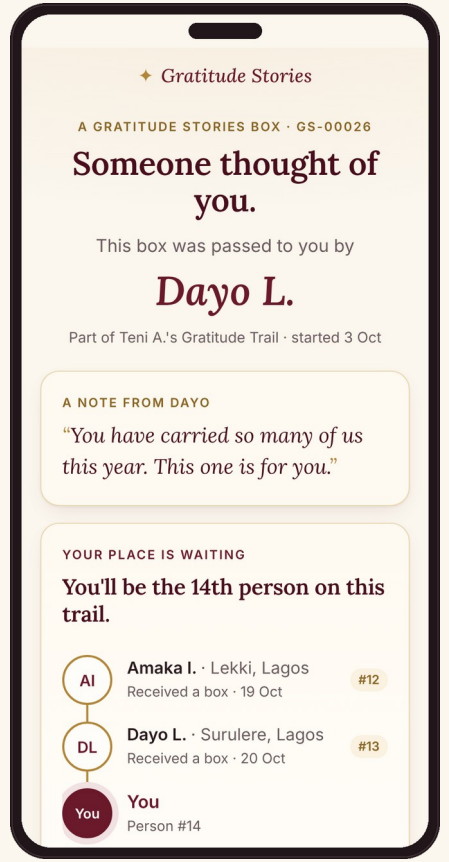
STATES 2 + 3 Delivered, waiting for “Yes”



The delivered message is the header; the question is the action. “Not yet / I need help” is never hidden.

Taps “Yes”

STATE 4 After “Yes, I have it”



The giver’s name, their note, the trail and the form arrive in sequence: a reveal, not a form first.

COMPONENT BREAKDOWN

One box page, routed by state

<BoxPage token>

Routes on box.status, received_at and the cookies on this phone

STATE 1

<TransitState>

```
<JourneyIllustration
   stops={4} current />
<StatusChip label time />
<EarlyConfirm />
   only when collected
<HelpLink />
```

Data box.status, step time

STATES 2 + 3

<DeliveredState>

```
<JourneyIllustration
   delivered />
<ConfirmCard>
   [Yes, I have it]
   [Not yet / I need help]
</ConfirmCard>
```

Data delivered_at, delivery_to

STATE 4

<RevealState>

```
<GiverReveal name />
<NoteCard text />
   packed and not hidden
<PlaceOnTrail position>
   <ThreadView bare />
<RegisterForm />
```

Data lineage, giver, note

ALWAYS AVAILABLE

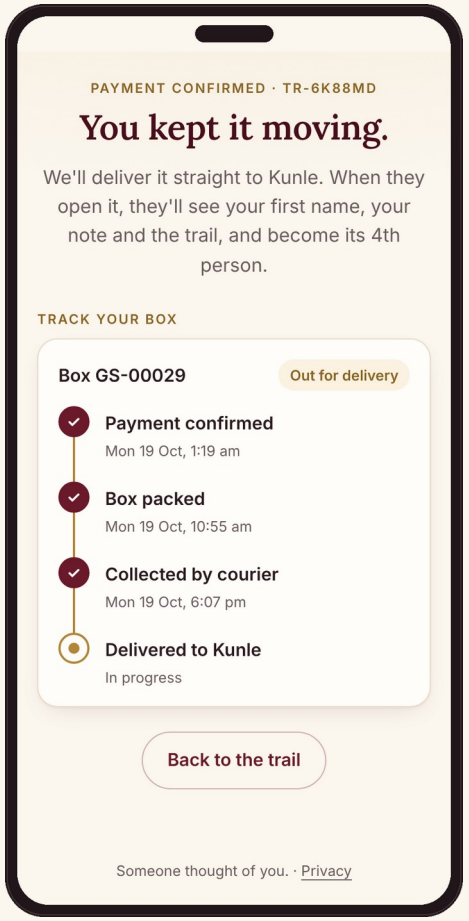
<Guards + Help>

```
<GiverDeviceNotice />
<NotFound /> <Inactive />
<HelpPage>
   phone (optional)
   [Ask us to check]
   [WhatsApp us]
```

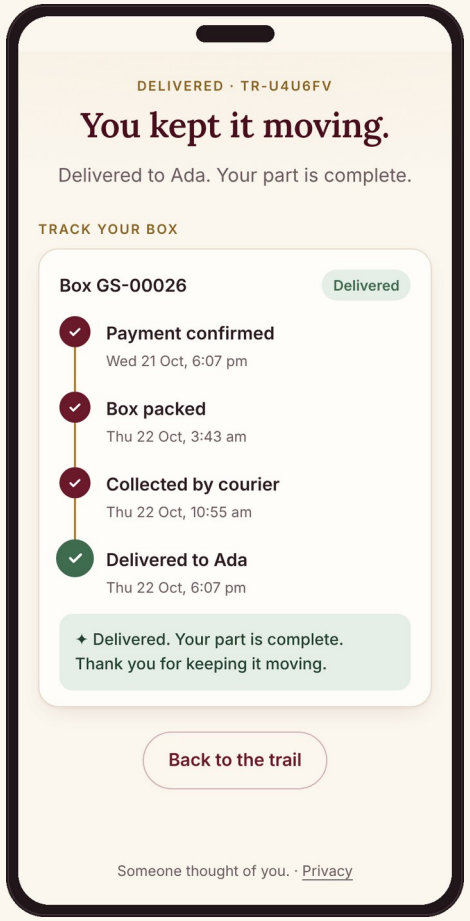
Data help_requests

In the MVP: transitPage, deliveredPage, revealPage and helpPage (src/views/pages.js), journeyIllustration (components.js), recipientJourney (src/lib/journey.js).

Complete at "Delivered", and silent after that



Out for delivery



Delivered: the finish line

Styling guidance

Done — Wine fill with a white check. The connector below it turns gold. Time in 13px muted text.

In progress — Gold ring with a gold centre dot and a soft halo pulse. The status pill says what is happening now.

Not yet — Dashed sand ring, label in muted 500 weight. Nothing to read into.

Delivered — 34px green check that settles in once, green pill, then "Your part is complete."

The privacy rule, built in

The tracker reads only payment, packed, collected and delivered times. It never reads whether the gift was confirmed, opened or registered, so it cannot leak them. A test compares the page before and after the recipient registers: identical.

Charity boxes join the headline numbers

1

PEOPLE REACHED

25

Confirmed: they received their box and added their name.

GENERATIONS

13

Confirmed levels of giving from your first gift.

2

CHARITY BOXES UNLOCKED

2

1 given through our partners · 1 being arranged

3

Milestones

4

People reached — 25 people · 25 to go to 50

Generations — 13 generations · 7 to go to 20



Gift stones unlock a charity box: a full box given through our partners to someone God knows.

5

REACHED

- 25 people reached 22 Oct
- 10 generations of giving 18 Oct
- 8th generation reached 14 Oct
- 10 people reached 13 Oct
- 5 generations of giving 10 Oct
- 5 people reached 8 Oct
- First branch: one person's two gifts both found their people 7 Oct
- 3 generations of giving 6 Oct

1 Headline row

People reached, Generations and Charity boxes unlocked, at equal size. Confirmed figures only.

2 The charity card

Gold-tinted so it stands out without shouting. Its sub-line separates given from being arranged.

3 People track

Stepping stones; gift stones unlock charity boxes. Only the nearest gift stones carry a label.

4 Generations track

Generation 8 is a gift stone. Reached stones fill gold or wine; the next one pulses softly.

5 Reached badges

Dated, newest first. Below them: the charity list, milestone cards, then the tree.

A thank-you Teni can keep, shown once, kept forever

A GRATITUDE STORIES MILESTONE

25

people have felt thought of

because of one box
Teni gave
on 3 October 2026.

This milestone unlocked a gift for someone God knows.

Teni's Gratitude Trail · TR-U4U6FV
Reached 22 October 2026

Motion: it rises gently, once. No confetti.

When it appears

The first visit after the trail reaches 25 confirmed people (then 50, 100 and 250).

How it appears

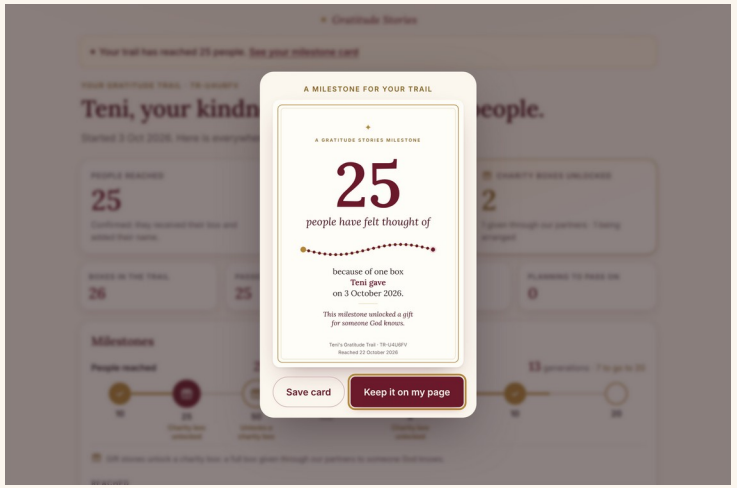
Once, as a modal card: focus stays inside it and Esc closes it. Without JavaScript, a gold notice links to it.

Where it stays

“Keep it on my page” moves it to the milestone cards gallery. “Save card” downloads it as an image.

What it shows

Only Teni’s first name, her trail code and dates. Nobody else on the trail.



On the dashboard, the first time

The words

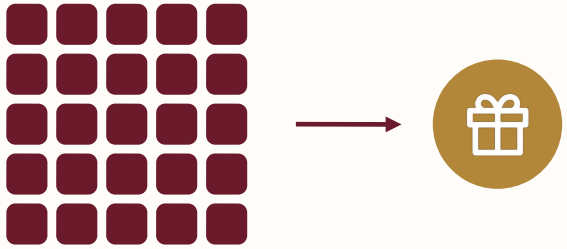
“25 people have felt thought of because of one box Teni gave on 3 October 2026. This milestone unlocked a gift for someone God knows.”

THE CHARITY ENGINE

Every unlocked box is a promise, so fund it first

Rule	Unlocks
Every 25 confirmed people (25, 50, 75 …)	1 charity box
The trail reaches generation 8 (once)	1 charity box
Counted from	Registrations only, never purchases
Where to change it	CHARITY_RULES in src/lib/milestones.js

What it costs



≈ 4%
of boxes, plus one at generation 8

Every 25 boxes bought and registered fund one charity box. Computed from the rule, not from real data.

Fund it before you announce it

From the box margin, a sponsor pool or a partner. If the money isn't there, set the rule to 0.

Give it for real

Through your partners, to someone God knows. Mark it given in admin; starters see "Given".

No leaderboards

Trails are never ranked against each other. The pull is the gift, not the competition.

THE MVP

Built and tested today; next after the pilot

29
automated tests passing

0
third-party packages

Node 22+
all it needs to run

In the MVP

- Box Journey: four recipient states
- “Yes, I have it” confirms receipt
- Trail View with position and milestones
- Pass it on: to me or straight to them
- Paystack payments, signed webhooks
- Giver tracker that stops at Delivered
- Gentle reminder: SMS, email, page
- Charity milestones and milestone card
- Starter dashboard and tree
- Admin: packing, notes, help, charity
- Printable QR cards, no outside service
- Tests that try to mix trails

After the pilot

- Sign-in by emailed code for starters
- Courier integration for live tracking
- WhatsApp reminders
- Private thank-you notes for Someone God Knows boxes
- Card stock printed in advance, bound at packing
- Milestone emails (after starter sign-in)
- PostgreSQL when one server is not enough

SUGGESTED TIMELINE

From MVP to a Christmas pilot in Lagos

Set up

26 Oct – 1 Nov

- Domain, hosting, HTTPS
- Paystack live key + webhook
- Real boxes and prices
- Privacy review starts

Dry run

2 – 8 Nov

- Staff trail, 3 generations
- Print and scan test cards
- Fix what breaks

Soft launch

9 – 22 Nov

- Friends and family
- Watch the numbers daily
- Talk to 10 recipients

Lagos pilot

23 Nov – 31 Dec

- Public launch for a Gratitude Christmas
- Weekly review

Payments work end to end
A live payment, then a refund

A dry-run trail reaches its 3rd person
On real phones and deliveries

Go or adjust
Against the continuation rate you set

Dates are a suggestion working back from Christmas 2026; the gates matter more than the dates.

BEFORE YOU LAUNCH

Eight decisions, then measure what matters

1. **The domain printed on every card** — It can never change once cards are out
2. **Pass-on box price and delivery fee** — The biggest driver of whether people continue
3. **Charity box funding** — Margin, sponsor or partner, before switching on
4. **Delivery options** — To the giver, straight to them, or both
5. **Consent and the under-18 rule** — Opt-in; under-18s shown as “A friend”
6. **Reminder channel** — Email first, SMS once a sender ID is approved
7. **Who runs fulfilment** — One named person for packing, couriers and help
8. **The continuation rate worth scaling** — Write it down before launch

MEASURE IN THE PILOT

Continuation rate

Registered recipients who pass at least one box on

Decision split
Yes, remind me, not this time

Checkout completion
From “Yes” to paid

Reminder rescue
Reminders that end in a pass-on

Trail depth
Generations per trail

DON’T KEEP IT IN. PASS IT ON.

Someone thought of you.

In this pack: the working MVP with the Box Journey update, the step-by-step build guide, and this deck.

